

Brussels defends its maritime ETS

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-17 14:02

【要点】

- ・ 欧州委員会は、海運ETS支援メカニズムについて限定的なアプローチを採用し、公的資金は持続可能な海運燃料と従来型燃料の価格差を埋めることに優先的に充てるべきと主張している。
- ・ 欧州委員会は2027年の議題に運輸簡素化パッケージを正式に追加した。
- ・ 連邦首脳会議での演説は自動車産業向けの具体的な詳細や施策が不足しており、業界と政策立案者の失望を招いている。

【メール原文】

Presented by BMW Group By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL A NOTE TO OUR READERS: Over the past week, you've been bombarded with dire warnings about AI'

Presented by BMW Group

By MARTINA SAPIO

with JORDYN DAHL

PRESENTED BY

View in your browser or listen to audio

A NOTE TO OUR READERS: Over the past week, you've been bombarded with dire warnings about AI's future, and a cacophony of voices insisting governments must take "some" action. But on what will actually be done, by whom and where — there are precious few voices offering clarity.

That's where POLITICO comes in.

On the most consequential story of our lifetimes — how governments around the world respond to the most powerful technology humans have ever built — clarity is our commitment to you. And it's why we're so proud to announce the launch of Decoded by POLITICO.

Decoded draws on POLITICO's unmatched ability to reveal who holds power, how they're using it, and what happens next in this moment where technology, power and policy are all colliding, with reporting from Silicon Valley, Washington, Sacramento, London, Brussels and beyond. Drawing on nearly 50 journalists around the world with expertise covering tech policy, Decoded will provide essential intelligence on the people, power moves and policy fights shaping the AI era.

Yesterday, we held our first Decoded Summit in Washington, with more Decoded Summits coming to other key capitals in the months ahead. A new daily newsletter and audio podcast, Decoded by POLITICO, launches Oct. 5. We hope you'll sign up for the newsletter [here](#) .

The AI revolution is the biggest news story of our lifetimes. Thank you for your continued trust in POLITICO to cover this story with the precision and depth it deserves.

— Goli Sheikholeslami, Jonathan Greenberger, Alex Burns, Chris Cadelago and Kate Day

SNEAK PEEK

— The European Commission defended its deliberately narrow approach to its new maritime ETS support mechanism, arguing that scarce public money should focus first on closing the price gap between conventional and sustainable shipping fuels.

— The Commission has formally put a transport simplification package on its 2027 agenda.

— The State of the Union speech lacked details or initiatives for the automotive industry, leaving the sector and policymakers disappointed.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

BRUSSELS DEFENDS ITS MARITIME ETS: The European Commission is defending a deliberately narrow approach to its new maritime ETS support mechanism, arguing that scarce public money should focus first on closing the price gap between conventional and sustainable shipping fuels rather than trying to subsidize every green technology.

Why fuels get priority: Speaking at an event on Tuesday, Polona Gregorin, head of DG CLIMA's unit for air, rail, water and intermodal policy, said the proposed SMAP mechanism is meant to target areas where the carbon price alone does not provide enough incentive. "You absolutely do need to bridge the price gap between ... a much more expensive sustainable fuel and conventional [fuel]," she said.

Reminder: SMAP — the proposed Sustainable Maritime Alternative Fuels and Propulsion support mechanism — is the Commission's maritime decarbonization scheme funded through the revised ETS . The Commission is proposing 110 million allowances, potentially worth around €15 billion through 2040, with the mechanism designed primarily to narrow the price gap between conventional and sustainable shipping fuels.

Energy efficiency left out: Energy-efficiency projects — such as hull, engine or retrofit improvements that cut the amount of fuel a ship uses — are not covered by SMAP. "Energy efficiency is not supported. That's true," Gregorin said. But she stressed that this was a choice to keep the mechanism focused and manageable, not a judgment that efficiency measures do not matter. "That is not to say that energy efficiency is not important — on the contrary, it's very, very important. But there might be better ways to support investment."

The Commission's logic: Efficiency measures can already produce direct savings by cutting fuel use, whereas cleaner fuels remain significantly more expensive and therefore need additional support. As Gregorin put it: "You use less fuel — it's a win-win."

Industry pushback: Shipbuilding and shipping representatives have argued that the scheme should cast a wider net and include more technologies, retrofits and energy-efficiency projects. Gregorin's response

was that every additional category would spread a limited pot of money more thinly and make the mechanism more complex to administer.

That's fair: Sotiris Raptis, secretary-general of European Shipowners (ECSA), said provisional in-house analysis suggests the sector would need twice the money currently earmarked just to meet the FuelEU Maritime sub-target alone. "More money should be earmarked for sustainable fuels and clean tech," he said, arguing that the Commission had taken a first step but that Parliament and Council now need to go further.

Timing: Gregorin also said the file could move unusually fast under the Irish presidency, with the aim of wrapping up the Council and European Parliament work before the end of 2026 and concluding negotiations by March next year. She acknowledged that would be "quite unprecedented," but added that, while the timetable is ambitious, capitals and lawmakers are already working at speed because several provisions are due to kick in from 2028.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising here .

STATE OF THE UNION

TRANSPORT OMNIBUS CONFIRMED: The European Commission has formally put a transport simplification package on its 2027 agenda, confirming the direction of travel POLITICO first reported in May when DG MOVE began preparing a sector-by-sector review of EU transport red tape. The package appears in Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union letter of intent under the competitiveness and jobs heading.

As we scooped: DG MOVE's June "Reality Check" workshops brought together aviation, maritime, rail and road stakeholders to identify EU rules creating unnecessary administrative burdens and to flag where requirements could be simplified or digitized. The Commission said the exercise was intended to collect first-hand evidence from practitioners on obstacles, unintended consequences and disproportionate compliance costs. The workshops took place on June 15 and 16, with aviation, maritime and inland navigation first, followed by road and rail.

What Brussels was looking for: Stakeholders were asked to point to pain points around reporting obligations, authorizations, permits, certifications, registrations, inspections and subsidy applications, as well as cases where companies are submitting information authorities already hold elsewhere. DG MOVE also wanted examples of where digital tools could eliminate duplicate paperwork.

Sector pain points: In aviation and maritime, the review was expected to pick up complaints around emissions reporting, fuel-compliance systems, safety certification and overlaps between EU and international rules. Rail and road groups, meanwhile, have long raised concerns around permitting, technical requirements, interoperability and freight documentation.

Now it becomes a package: What was initially a technical stocktake is now feeding into a formal simplification initiative. The State of the Union letter does not yet spell out which regulations or directives will be reopened, so the scope of the omnibus remains unclear. But its inclusion in the 2027 work program means transport is now explicitly part of the Commission's broader push to cut burdens on business.

Background: Brussels has set itself a wider target of cutting administrative burdens by at least 25% for companies and 35% for SMEs, and transport operators have been among the sectors pushing hardest for relief. The political fight now will be over whether the omnibus mostly tidies reporting and paperwork — or becomes an opportunity to reopen substantive sectoral rules that industry has been lobbying to change.

****Don't miss exclusive insights on von der Leyen's State of the Union speech. In our virtual briefing today, Sept. 17, at 4 p.m. CEST, POLITICO's policy reporters will break down the speech's key proposals — from a potential security council and closer ties with Canada to climate resilience and protecting children online. Sign up now .****

STATE OF THE UNION LANDS WITH A WHISPER: You can't say we didn't warn you . While Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's speeches in years past have been used to launch the small car initiative or announce an anti-subsidy investigation into Chinese EVs, this year's barely even touched upon competitiveness.

What it missed: The president made some remarks about tackling Chinese exports but continued her line that "this is why we are engaged in a dialogue with China." Automakers hoping to get a hint as to which countries would make the trusted partner list under the Industrial Accelerator Act were sorely disappointed.

What it did include: The speech announced more actions to stockpile critical raw materials needed for electric vehicles and the batteries that power them. The Commission will establish a new corporation tasked with coordinating purchases and building a stockpile of the goods.

Unimpressed: The German car lobby VDA came out swinging against the speech, saying in a statement to media that von der Leyen "presented little to no new, concrete solutions or courses of action" to help make the bloc's industries more competitive. "Concrete answers were particularly needed for the German and European automotive industry—one of the most important key sectors. Yet this did not happen," VDA President Hildegard Müller said in the statement.

****Your next Playbook speaks Spanish. Madrid Playbook brings POLITICO's original reporting, sharp analysis and essential political agenda to Spain every morning. Learn more and sign up here .****

Some agreement: The one thing both the far right and the left can agree on is a new for local content requirements. French MEP Jordan Bardella, chair of the far-right Patriots, said that public money should only go to companies employing European workers. "We need to make European public procurement a genuine weapon like China or the U.S.," French MEP Valérie Hayer, head of the Renew group, said in her remarks after von der Leyen.

Missing a backbone: "We adopted a Green Deal. Let's stop unravelling it and implement it, for goodness sake," Hayer said. Much of von der Leyen's speech focused on the climate and massive wildfires from the summer.

Promises to keep: The EPP's Manfred Weber, meanwhile, used climate to reiterate the party's campaign promise to "stop the ban on the combustion engine," referring to the legislation that previously mandated the sale of a 100 percent zero-emission vehicles starting in 2035. The Commission's proposed reform that is currently under negotiations in the institutions would allow powertrains past 2035 but with various emission offsets.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

****A message from BMW Group: Ambitious targets cannot create demand on their own. Europe's mobility transition will only succeed if it is attractive, affordable and practical for consumers and businesses. BMW Group's Dr. Frank Niederländer explores what Europe needs to turn ambition into uptake here .****

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising here .

CARS

EPP NEGOTIATIONS ON IAA: The center-right European People's Party is meeting at 9 a.m. today to discuss the Industrial Accelerator Act. The party's national delegations submitted their thoughts on the Commission's grand industrial strategy. EPP leaders will have plenty to comb through today.

Reminder: We scooped the contributions from 12 member states earlier this month. Finding a common position in Brussels won't be an easy task. The national delegations are split over everything from whether the IAA should have a binding manufacturing target to which products should be included. Catch up on that here .

Does it matter? None of the file's rapporteurs in Parliament are from the EPP, but it is the largest group in the institution, meaning its votes will carry weight.

Tick tock: A committee vote on the IAA is scheduled for Dec. 1 with a possible plenary vote in mid-December, giving policymakers little time to reach an agreement. When asked when the EPP could come to a common stance, an MEP told Jordyn it would be before Christmas.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

****A message from BMW Group: Europe's automotive industry is entering a crucial decade. As manufacturers navigate electrification, global competition, geopolitical uncertainty and rising energy costs, Europe faces the challenge of delivering decarbonization while strengthening competitiveness and resilience. In this Q&A , POLITICO Studio speaks to Dr. Frank Niederländer, Vice President for Government Affairs Europe at BMW Group, about the choices and conditions that will shape the next phase of Europe's automotive transition. He discusses how Europe can strengthen the industrial base behind the transition, what it will take to build a competitive battery ecosystem and why establishing new capabilities requires the right investment conditions — and time to scale. He also explores why policymakers should look beyond tailpipe emissions to consider the full value chain, and the potential role of renewable fuels alongside electrification. And why the transition will only succeed if it works for consumers and businesses while keeping investment, innovation and value creation in Europe.****

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising here .

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

EU blindsided by von der Leyen's Canada 'associate member' pitch

The Commission president unveiled the idea without consulting EU capitals — and Ottawa quickly tamped down expectations.

By Sebastian Starcevic, Max Grier · Sept 16, 2026, 07:33 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

12 takeaways from von der Leyen's State of the Union

Everything you need to know about what was said — and not said — in the European Commission president's big speech.

By Sebastian Starcevic · Sept 16, 2026, 01:19 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU capitals caught off guard as von der Leyen announces 'associate membership' for Canada

Further alignment than currently planned would create new issues around steel, cars, genetically modified crops and other substantive issues, diplomats said.

By Gabriel Gavin · Sept 16, 2026, 12:30 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Von der Leyen tries to stem tide on global threats — from Trump to AI and climate

At time of "great perils," the State of the Union speech pushes European "independence" while floating unique "associate membership" for Canada.

By Gerardo Fortuna · Sept 16, 2026, 10:56 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Von der Leyen pitches Japan-style critical minerals vehicle to build stockpiles

By Carlo Martuscelli · Sept 16, 2026, 09:35 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Von der Leyen to launch new trade and freight routes

By Jordyn Dahl · Sept 16, 2026, 09:30 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Von der Leyen gives single market top billing in annual address

By Francesca Micheletti, Aude van den Hove · Sept 16, 2026, 09:28 am Europe/Brussels CEST

EU-China trade deficit has hit 'tipping point,' warns von der Leyen

"We will use all tools at our disposal to rebalance our relationship," says European Commission president.

By Camille Gijs, Carlo Martuscelli, Gerardo Fortuna · Sept 16, 2026, 09:12 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Pro Intelligence Connections

2021/0210(COD) Sustainable maritime fuels (FuelEU...

Final act published in Official Journal

This email alert has been sent for your exclusive use as a POLITICO Pro subscriber. Forwarding or reproducing the newsletter without the express, written permission of POLITICO Pro is a violation of the POLITICO Pro license agreement.

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update settings](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium